

Conversation

#12

CONVERSATION

A PRESIDENTIAL DEBATE

Teacher's note: get 6 pieces of papers, number them 1 to 6 and have each student draw one, to see which character they will be.

You will take part in a nationally televised presidential debate. Three candidates will answer questions from three journalists. Each candidate will respond to each question. Journalists should make some notes about the questions they want to ask before beginning this activity.

1 Candidate 1: the latest polls indicate that this will be a very close election. You are a right-wing conservative candidate. You are on the side of big businesses because you believe this is the best way to create new jobs. For this reason, you want to introduce new tax benefits for large business owners. There seems to be some speculation about your campaign contributions, but you will try to avoid questions concerning this subject. You also firmly believe that money cannot be considered as a motivational tool for employees.

2 Candidate 2: the latest polls indicate that this will be a very close election. You are a left-wing liberal. You believe the rich have too many benefits from the government, including tax breaks on exports, etc. Your main focus is on education. You believe that we must improve the education system in order to be competitive in the future. Public teachers' salaries have remained the same for the past four years because the current president, who is from the same party as Candidate 1, refused to authorize pay increases for the teachers. You believe this directly affects the quality of education. You have plans for social programs that will improve the education system.

3 Candidate 3: the latest polls indicate that this will be a very close election. You are a moderate candidate. Your main focus is on health and women's rights. You firmly believe in equal pay for equal work. You also want to improve the national health care system. You want to tax big businesses more to pay for improvements in the health care system. After all, the workers of the big businesses need the system more, while the rich have private health care plans and can afford to pay more taxes.

4 Journalist 1: you work for the television channel this debate is being broadcasted on. It's up to you to maintain control over the candidates and the other journalists. The election is expected to be very close. You will begin the debate by introducing the candidates and the other journalists. Next, you choose a journalist to ask the first question for all three candidates. Your own questions concern poverty, education, and the public health system.

5 Journalist 2: you work for The New York Times and are known for asking very difficult questions. This has gotten you into trouble with politicians in the past. However, this is why you are so respected in your field. You have discovered that Candidate 1 has received illegal campaign contributions. You want him to explain himself. Your other questions concern women and minorities' rights. Also, the current president made many promises that he didn't keep. Candidate 1 is of the same party. Ask Candidate 1 why we should believe in his party ever again.

6 Journalist 3: you work for a political magazine, and you expect this election to be very close. Even though you are a journalist and supposed to be unbiased, secretly you are more conservative. You don't agree with very liberal ideas and even think they can be dangerous. Your main focus is on the economy, violence, and foreign relations.

COMPOSITION

Write about the current president and politics in general. Do you agree with what the current administration is doing? Why or why not?

Full name: _____

Theme: _____

Title: _____

[illegible]